Even those who could not converse could still exchange gifts – our tea for their coffee, our corned meat for their sausage. Badges and buttons from uniforms changed owners, and one of our boys walked off with a spiked helmet! I myself traded a jack knife for a leather equipment belt – a fine souvenir to show when I get home.

As it grew late, a few more songs were traded around the fire, and then all joined in for – I am not lying to you – "Auld Lang Syne." Then we parted with promises to meet again tomorrow, and there was even some talk of a football match.

I was just starting back to the trenches when an older German soldier clutched my arm. "My God," he said, "why cannot we have peace and all go home?"

I told him gently, "That you must ask your emperor."

He looked at me searchingly and said, "Perhaps, my friend. But we must also ask our hearts." And so, dear sister, tell me, has there ever been such a Christmas Eve in all history? What does it all mean, this impossible befriending of enemies?

For the fighting here, of course, it means regrettably little. Decent fellows those soldiers may be, but they follow orders and we do the same. Besides, we are here to stop their army and send it home, and never could we shirk that duty.

Still, one cannot help but imagine what would happen if the spirit shown here were caught by the nations of the world. Disputes may arise but what if our leaders were to offer good wishes in place of warnings; songs in place of insults; gifts in place of reprisals? Would not all wars end at once?

All nations say they want peace. Yet on this Christmas morning, I wonder if we want it quite enough.

Your loving brother,
Tom



About the Author



Aaron Shepard (October 7, 1950) is the award-winning author of Savitri: A Tale of Ancient India, The Legend of Lightning Larry, The Sea King's Daughter, and many more children's books. Aaron's specialty is retelling folktales and other traditional literature from around the world. His work has been honoured by the American Library Association, the National Council for the Social Studies, the American Folklore Society, the New York Public Library, and the Bank Street College of Education.

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